Our arrival in France transferred the sleepy St Marcel community into a bubbling mini-India. Vendors came with bread, milk and meat, and became friendly with the Indian community. Our scientists' wives, especially the Malayalees, boasted that they would learn French faster than the men, since they got to interact with hawkers who spoke no other language. We wished them all the best. And, at the end of a few months, our women could barely pronounce 'bonjour'. On their part, the hawkers went back speaking Malayalam.

Having come to know about the large number of Indians who had moved into St Marcel, a French social security volunteer named Mary came to meet me. Mademoisille Mary was to soon endear herself to our community by becoming a champion of our causes—monetary, medical and social. She was a godsend in many ways, as the Government of India had not only failed to offer social security measures to the scientists on assignment, it even denied the team a basic medical cover. One of the first things I did was to create a medical corpus fund with every scientist pooling in an equal amount, but this was grossly insufficient if any one of us had a serious ailment. And, as fate would have it, there were three medical emergencies within the first two years.

The first such crisis was because of a scientist breaking the Vernon recruitment rule that nobody should bring pregnant wives along. The scientist, who was married only for a few months before he was selected for the Vernon team, did not disclose the fact that his wife was in the early stages of pregnancy. In April 1975, she delivered a girl with a congenital problem of one of the lungs.

The newborn was put on ventilator, and the daily bill came to 800 Francs. There was uncertainty on how long she could be kept on the ventilator. Doctors said her condition was deteriorating, and the normal practice in such cases is to keep the baby in the ventilator for not more than three days. The baby's parents were probably not informed now about the gravity of the situation.

'What does that mean?' I asked a doctor.

'Well, that means the end of the treatment.'